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Decisions Handoff Guide

Use this guide when you need to describe **important choices, why they were made, what options were considered, and what impact they have.**

This guide is about explicit rationale, not hidden assumptions.

KNOWLEDGE AREA

This guide helps with **important choices and why they were made.**
Technically, it covers **decision rationale and governance traceability.**

Guide family map

Where this guide sits in the full Blueprint Handoff Atlas family.

ROOT & CROSS-CUTTING

Handoff Atlas

Blueprint Bundle

Metamodel Vocabulary

Migrations

DESIGN

Architecture

Concepts

Domain

Dynamics

Infrastructure

Interactions

Models

Quality

Rules

Story

GOVERNANCE

Capability

Decisions

Motivation

Organization

Roadmap

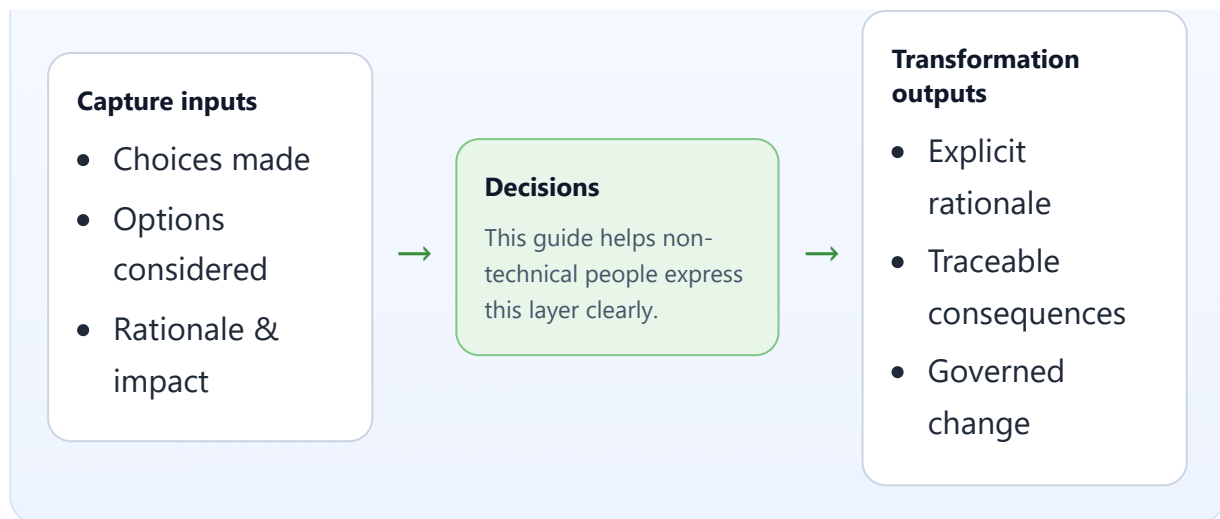
Leverage

Test Cases

Value Stream

Capture → focus → transformation

What to gather first, what this layer focuses on, and what a modeler or AI agent can produce from it.



Main entities in this guide

- **Decision** — a recorded architecture or policy choice with status, rationale, and impact.
- **Business Decision** — a business-governance choice whose consequences shape the model or delivery.
- **Option** — an alternative that was considered before the final choice.
- **Rationale** — the reasoning that explains why the chosen option won.
 - Often confused with: an **Assumption** in Motivation. A decision is a committed choice; an assumption is something believed true but not yet proven.

What belongs here

- architecture or policy decisions
- business decisions with lasting effect
- status of decisions (proposed, accepted, etc.)
- rationale, trade-offs, and impact

What does not belong here

- raw brainstorming with no actual decision
- generic requirements with no choice or rationale
- goals or risks by themselves without a decision attached

Core things to capture

- what was decided
- why it was decided

- what options were considered
- what impact areas are affected
- what motivation, risk, or trade-off shaped the choice

Core relationships to capture

- decision -> affected area
- decision -> goal/risk/assumption/trade-off motivating it
- decision -> status or superseding decision

Modus operandi

Document decisions when a real choice has been made:

1. state the decision clearly
2. explain the problem or context
3. record the main options considered
4. explain the rationale
5. state the impact and status

Prompt set

- what choice was made?
- what problem or tension did it address?
- what options were on the table?
- why was this option chosen?
- what will it affect?

Free-text intake template

- **Decision title:**
- **Context/problem:**
- **Options considered:**
- **Chosen option:**
- **Why:**
- **Impacted areas:**
- **Status/date:**
- **Related goals/risks/assumptions:**

Worked example

- Decision: eligible return requests are auto-approved within policy thresholds
- Context: operations wants faster customer resolution and lower support volume
- Options: manual support review for every request vs policy-based auto-approval
- Chosen: policy-based auto-approval
- Impact: workflow, authorization, audit trail, support dashboard

Layer-specific handoff guidance

For decisions, the handoff should preserve **choice and rationale together**.

The receiver should not have to guess:

- what was decided
- what alternatives were considered
- why this option won
- what areas are affected

If the rationale is missing, the handoff captures a conclusion but not a decision.

How this becomes YAML

A technical modeler or AI agent can transform this into decisions or business decisions with status, rationale, and typed impact references.

Common mistakes

- recording the conclusion but not the reason
- forgetting rejected options
- omitting affected areas
- confusing an assumption with a decision